that the youngest amongst them was also, perhaps, the most powerful.

~

Humayun never made it to Qandahar. He had been warned that his brother Askari, who held the city as Kamran's deputy, would not allow Humayun into it; that he would, in fact, attack and imprison his former king. Humayun responded with a reproving letter to his 'little-loving, disloyal brother' – but if he meant to induce any guilt in his kin, he failed. As Abul Fazl laments, 'where was there the reason-hearkening ear . . .?'

The very next day, a young Uzbek came galloping into the camp at full throttle, demanding to see Humayun. When a servant indicated where his master was resting and invited the Uzbek to get off his horse, the young man merely 'twisted the reins about his hand', rode behind the screen where Humayun lay, and woke him up. 'Myrza Askery is coming to attack you,' he said.[7]

Gulbadan writes that Humayun fled immediately and was 'two arrows' flight' gone before he sent for Hamida. Jouher and Abul Fazl both have the fallen emperor proposing battle, a brave idea vetoed by Bairam ('there are but few of us'[8]); but only Jouher tells of how, at this critical moment, Humayun was short, once again, of a horse for his wife. Once again, he asked that churl, Tardi Beg, to lend him one, and once again, Tardi Beg refused. This time, in fact, he refused any kind of service at all, having no more interest, evidently, in another bout of uncertain vagabonding in Humayun's company. With Tardi Beg so intractable and little time to lose, Humayun took Hamida upon his own horse and began to ride west, seeking no more kingdoms, but only refuge.

They left their son behind.

According to Gulbadan, this was because there was 'not a chink of time' in which to take him; according to Abul Fazl, it was because Humayun knew his son was protected by 'Divine love'. Neither explanation is very satisfactory. Jouher's unhappy scene, however, suggests a more credible cause for the abandonment: Hamida and Humayun, with one horse between them and no idea of their future, had every reason to think it more practical, even safer, to leave their son behind.

Back in the camp, Akbar would have food, at least, and warmth and loyal